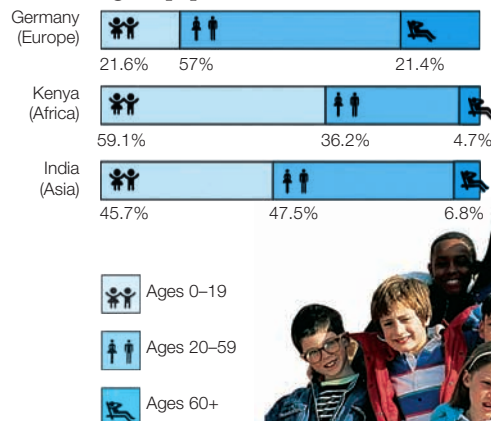




THE CHANGING POPULATION

Compared to Asia and Africa, the populations of most European countries are stable – they are not increasing or decreasing to any great extent. Birth rates are low, and average life expectancy is very high – about 75 years in most countries, compared to less than 50 years in Afghanistan and most of Africa. As a result of these two factors, Europe's population is relatively elderly, with a large number of people aged 60 years and over.

Age of population



A market in the Russian Federation. Under communism all commerce was controlled by the State



CULTURAL MELTING POT

Europe's wealth and relative political stability have attracted large numbers of migrants to its shores, many from former colonies. As a result, most countries, particularly in western Europe, contain large numbers of people from ethnic minorities. In France, for example, north Africans from Algeria and other former colonies have settled in cities such as Marseilles and Paris.



The UK's population contains migrants from many countries, including the Caribbean, India, Pakistan, and Bangladesh.

New European countries



SPLITTING APART

Europe is a fragmented continent made up of more than 40 independent countries. Even within individual countries there are sometimes separate groups, such as the Basques in Spain, who claim some form of independence from the national government. New countries are still being formed. The former USSR, Yugoslavia, and Czechoslovakia are among the European countries that have split apart in recent years, sometimes violently.



THE EUROPEAN UNION

In 1957, six European countries agreed to form the European Economic Community (EEC). They believed that economic cooperation would reduce the likelihood of war between the member countries and would bring prosperity to the peoples of

Europe. Since that time, more countries have joined, and the EEC has been renamed the European Union (EU). Today it consists of 27 member states and in addition to closer economic cooperation, there are moves to encourage greater political union.

